the family was very proud of it. We also spoke to several women who worked outdoors in the fields at the commune; under China's new policies, they told us they were allowed to sell in the open market anything they produced that exceeded quotas set by the government, providing them some of the incentive inherent in the free market. From Shanghai, we flew to Fairbanks, Alaska, for an overnight stop and a brief visit with Pope John Paul II, who was on his way to South Korea, and then home to Washington.

During my remaining four and a half years in the White House, I continued to take a great interest in the changes slowly coming to China. It was still a decidedly Communist country, but in encouraging small businesses and freeing farm workers from their collective farms, allowing them to lease the land they had tilled and to share in the profits from it, they were creating entrepreneurs. Whatever they called it, it was the beginning of a free enterprise system—and with it, they increased agricultural productivity in some areas by almost four times.

I don't claim the vision to have foreseen in 1984 all the dramatic changes that came later to the Communist world. But the events in China and Poland made me feel optimistic; they were an exciting glimmer on the horizon, the first public admission in the Communist world that Communism wasn't working . . . a harbinger of its collapse.

Only history can tell us where China will go from here. The Chinese leadership's brutal crackdown on students seeking fundamental democratic rights makes it difficult to chart the future. Those brave students who laid down their lives against the tanks of Tiananmen Square confirmed what I'd always believed: that no totalitarian society can bottle up the instinctive drive of men and women to be free, and that once you give a captive people a little freedom, they'll demand more. Still, as I watched that drama unfold and learned of the students' fate, I couldn't help but wonder if it